

By HILAL AHMED

THE NEW CONFLICT TRAJECTORIES

THE HINDU-MUSLIM BINARY IS STILL A POWERFUL POLITICAL REFERENCE POINT. THE BJP'S FAILURE TO GET A MAJORITY ON ITS OWN HAS NOT DEFUSED THE COMMUNAL RHETORIC, BUT THE RSS'S PUSHBACK AGAINST FRINGE HINDUTVA ELEMENTS IS A POSITIVE SIGN

The outcome of the 2024 general election, especially the failure of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) to secure a majority on its own in the Lok Sabha, was seen as an ideological defeat of radical Hindutva. A section of political observers even hoped the decline of one-party dominance at the national level would defuse the aggressive anti-Muslim communal rhetoric. The post-election political developments, however, show that not much has changed.

The Hindu-Muslim binary continues to survive as a powerful political reference point. The ongoing debates on a few legally disputed Muslim places of worship, especially the Gyanvapi mosque in Varanasi and the Shahi Eidgah in Mathura, have intensified. A new set of petitions have been filed in various courts to evaluate the religious character of historic mosques, including the famous shrine of Khwaja Moinuddin Chishti in Ajmer. In fact, the Archaeological Survey of India's intervention in the case of the Shahi Jama Masjid of Sambhal led to violence in which four people died. The government also presented the controversial Waqf Bill in Parliament, which seeks to make serious changes in Muslim endowment management in the country. The proliferation of these seemingly communal issues reveals that the nature of public discourse has not changed significantly after the 2024 election.

There are two ways to make sense of the events of the past six months. The simple explanation is that aggressive Hindutva has not lost its rhetorical value and, for that reason, these extreme fringe groups have decided to embrace it as the most reliable mode of politics. This simple reading is not entirely incorrect. However, one needs to go beyond this ready-to-use response. The nature of contemporary Hindutva as a form of politics and its varied manifestations must be analysed carefully. In this sense, the challenges faced by the self-claimed Hindutva groups and the internal power structure of the Sangh parivar become very important.

Broadly speaking, we can make an analytical distinction between two kinds of issues that have emerged in the post-Lok Sabha election context: the provocative contestations and the structural ones. The petitions questioning the lawfulness of historic mosques symbolise the provoca-

> THE SIMPLE EXPLANATION IS THAT **AGGRESSIVE HINDUTVA HAS NOT LOST ITS RHETORICAL VALUE**, WHICH IS WHY THE FRINGE GROUPS KEEP AT IT

Illustration by NILANJAN DAS